

Finance Committee Meeting – Town Hall

February 25, 2026

Present: Tad Weiss (chair), Jennifer Milikowsky (taking notes), Jeremy Durrin, Jon Albitz, Maureen Dempsey, Steve Holt, Scott Stanton

Also present: Doug Finn, Greg Reynolds, Brad Morse, Meaghan Schwelm, Anne Marie O'Reilly, Others as noted

Weiss called the meeting to order 7:01PM

Durrin motion to accept 1/28/26 minutes. Albitz second. Vote: 7-0-0

Library Budget Discussion

Proposed library level services budget - slight reduction due to Friends of Westhampton Library pledging to support \$3,000 in landscaping.

Austerity budget risks loss of state aid. Library Director Meaghan Schwelm introduced Cate Merlin of the Massachusetts Libraries Board of Library Commissioners to present on state certification and state aid.

Municipal Appropriation Requirement (MAR) - requirement that towns are doing their best to support their library. Includes about a 1% increase in budget appropriated from the town year over year.

In addition to meeting the MAR, to qualify for state aid libraries must be open a set number of hours based on population and to increase funding year over year on library materials.

The State will certify the library if these requirements are met. The library will then receive state aid and the library's patrons get access to all 367 libraries across the state and all of their materials through CWMARS.

FY27 \$137,092 is Westhampton's MAR requirement, if not met, there's a waiver process - municipality not the library, has to apply for a waiver of the MAR. Hours open and investment in materials must be met to be certified - no waiver for that component

For the waiver, operating budgets of other town departments will be compared to the library budget. 5% threshold differential to demonstrate the library isn't receiving unequal burden of cuts. Up to 5 years of waivers are allowed, but after that town must get back to the MAR level. FY31 MAR will be \$146,614. If MAR is not met one year, it gets exponentially harder to meet MAR in subsequent years.

The library budget requires no appropriation for programming. All covered by grants or Friends of Westhampton Library Group.

FY27 Review

Discussion about override timing and amount. With a ~\$750,000 budget deficit at full level services, how much should be closed through cuts and how much through a potential override. Already identified about \$170,000 of cuts possible within a "level services" budget. Working on identifying enough additional cuts to constitute a balanced austerity budget should an override fail. Discussion on draft informational presentation.

Motion from Weiss - Finance Committee recommends the Selectboard put forth a warrant for a \$500,000 override to pay for general government and school budgets. Durrin second.

Vote: 6-0-0 (*Stanton left at 8:37pm before vote*)

Holt motion to adjourn. Durrin second. **Vote: 6-0-0**

Meeting adjourned at 9:06pm